

Principled Variations in Lyrics Segmentation

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In music video (MV) subtitling, spatial breaks segment a line of Chinese lyrics at preferred positions. Evidence can be found across different MV releases of the same track, where only a fraction of logically possible segmentations is attested. This phenomenon is illustrated in (1) and (2), where a sequence of abstract characters (A-Q) represents a lyric line from Sham's (2022) *Come What May*.

(1)



A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N	O	P	Q
記	不	記	得	你	將	證	件	與	機	票	連	著	一	份	渴	望
gei3bat1	gei3dak1			nei3	jeung1	jing3gin2	yu3	gei1piu3	lin4jeuk3	yat1fan6	hok3mong6					

remember-not-remember you OBJECT MARKER passport and flight ticket with one CLASSIFIER hope
 'Do you remember [packing] your passport and flight tickets, along with a sense of hope [...]'

(2) Preferred spatial segmentations of (1) in different MVs

- ABCD EFGH IJK LMNOPQ
- ABCD EFGHIJK LMNOPQ
- ABCDEFGH IJKLMNOPQ

Across multiple MVs, spatial breaks were found only in three positions (after D, H, and K). While the breaks align with musically longer notes, not all lengthened notes license spatial breaks. Other than the musical phrasing, the spatial segmentation reflects a certain morphosyntactic structural sensitivity. For instance, the break between D + [rel. cl E...Q] is the boundary of the embedded relative clause. However, one does not find spatial breaks within FGH, even though it is syntactically F + [G...K].

Spatial distribution of lyric subtitles reflects intricate relationships between morphosyntactic structures and musical prosodies. Admittedly, lyrics are complicated by poetic license and spacings are likely to be deliberately placed to create additional meanings. However, the distribution of spatial breaks is also constrained by grammatical principles that govern the interface between visual presentation, syntax, and musical prosody. This paper attempts to uncover some of these principles as seen through MVs of Cantonese songs. The research promises insight into Cantonese prosody where evidence from tone sandhi is lacking.

REFERENCE

Sham, Yoyo 岑寧兒 (2022) *Come What May* 《風的形狀》 [Song].
https://youtu.be/KEb1Db47DAg?si=K_N3_66Cu7oS_kXR

*Acknowledgement withheld to preserve anonymity.